

or rejected them. **Evidently the dimensions of the New Testament Canon recognized by Irenaeus are very close to what we hold today.**

From the time of Irenaeus on there can be no doubt concerning the attitude of the Church toward the New Testament writings—they are Scripture. Tertullian (in 208) said of the church at Rome, “the law and the prophets she unites in one volume with the writings of evangelists and apostles” (*Prescription against Heretics*, 36).

Attention please! The contribution of the evidence so far presented to our discussion is this: the implications of their attitude towards the Text. Whether or not someone today agrees with them is beside the point. The early Christians believed that the NT ‘books’ were divinely inspired, constituting a second Canon. As a consequence of their belief, they would treat those writings with care and respect.

### **Were Early Christians Careful?**

It has been widely affirmed that the early Christians were either unconcerned or unable to watch over the purity of the text. (Recall Hort’s words given above.) Again a review of the premises is called for. Many of the first believers had been devout Jews who had an ingrained reverence and care for the Old Testament Scriptures which extended to the very jots and tittles. This reverence and care would naturally be extended to the New Testament Scriptures.

Why should modern critics assume that the early Christians, in particular the spiritual leaders among them, were inferior in integrity or intelligence? A Father’s quoting from memory, or tailoring a passage to suit his purpose in sermon or letter, by no means implies that he would take similar liberties when transcribing a book or corpus. Ordinary honesty would require him to produce a faithful copy. Are we to assume that everyone who made copies of New Testament books in those early years was a knave, or a fool? Paul was certainly as intelligent a man as any of us. If Hebrews was written by someone else, here was another man of high spiritual insight and intellectual power. There was Barnabas and Apollos and Clement and Polycarp, etc., etc. The Church has had men of reason and intelligence all down through the years. Starting out with what they **knew** to be the pure text, the earliest Fathers did not need to be textual critics. They had only to be reasonably honest and careful. But is there not good reason to believe they would be **especially** watchful and careful?